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COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Vice President Client Sales and Support at Safelite AutoGlass Believes AI Voice Agents Are Transforming Customer Service Operations

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
08 Oct 2026	10 Jul 2026	Customer	Investor-Led (Buy-Side)	SIERRA

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covers the organization's adoption and scaling of AI voice agents in customer service, detailing the evaluation, implementation, and operational impact of Sierra's solution. Discussion includes digital transformation, vendor selection, integration challenges, pricing models, and future outlook for AI in contact center operations.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Over six years leading sales contact center and store operations for a large, nationwide organization with over 13,000 employees and 900+ store locations, including 7,000+ mobile units.
- Direct experience managing a third-party administrator (TPA) business serving over 8 million customers annually, handling claims for 192+ insurance carriers and managed fleets, and overseeing a virtual contact center with nearly 5,600 agents.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- **Highly positive on the impact and ROI of AI voice agents, particularly Sierra, in improving efficiency, reducing costs,** and enhancing customer experience.
- Believes the future is digital-first, with AI agents expected to handle the majority of intake volume, leading to eventual headcount reductions as comfort with AI grows among clients and regulators.
- Expresses **strong loyalty to Sierra due to their nimbleness**, partnership approach, and integration capabilities, but remains open to reevaluation if a superior solution emerges or if significant issues arise.

TAKEAWAYS

- The organization transitioned from brick-and-mortar contact centers to a fully virtual model post-pandemic, enabling flexible staffing and nationwide coverage.
- **Initial AI use case focused on automating repetitive first notice of loss** (FNOL) intake, freeing human agents for complex escalations and improving key metrics such as speed of answer, handle time, and cost per transaction.
- **Sierra was selected after a rigorous evaluation process against competitors like Decagon, Fin, Zendesk, and others, primarily due to their consultative approach, deep Salesforce integration, and nimbleness in product development**.
- Implementation of Sierra's AI agents was rapid, with native Salesforce integration enabling pilot deployment within a month; subsequent phases addressed more complex workflows like appointment scheduling and supply chain coordination.
- Sierra's outcome-based pricing is considered cost-effective and flexible, with contract amendments reflecting evolving use cases and volume commitments; exclusivity in the industry is currently maintained until contract expiration.

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Expert Bio

Vice President Client Sales And Support At Safelite Solutions at Safelite AutoGlass. Expert can speak to their direct experience with Sierra AI, including their role in deploying AI solutions to enhance customer support operations. Vice President of Client Sales and Support at Safelite Solutions. The expert is responsible for strategic sales growth with top clients, leading digital initiatives to enhance customer experience and efficiency, and developing agency awareness campaigns to drive loyalty and market share. Prior to Safelite, the expert was a Regional Sales Manager at Steelcase, leaving in January 2021. The expert was responsible for increasing revenue through channel

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partner engagement, implementing global sales strategies, securing major federal contracts, and leading DEI initiatives. The expert can speak to auto glass industry trends, insurance claim dynamics, sales strategy, customer experience innovation, and agency-carrier relationships.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

By way of background, we are doing research on the voice AI space, specifically with the focus on customer service agents, and wanted to talk with you given your profile as listed you as a customer of Sierra. Before we go into specific questions on the company, it'd be really helpful if you could just share a bit more detail on your background and the size and scope of the organization that you're at.

Expert 00:00:23

Absolutely. I've led the sales contact center and store operations functions for my organization for just over six years now. I came up through the ranks working in the contact center, also working in sales. We're a lot bigger than people think we are, but we have over 13,000 employees. We're across all 50 states with about 900 store locations. What a lot of people don't realize is, and this is the part of the business that I am in charge of, we are a TPA or a third-party administrator for over 192, last time I counted, insurance carriers and managed fleet companies. Think of AWS, FedEx, UPS, as well as national dealership chains like a Carvana. When I say insurance carriers, pretty much anyone you've seen a commercial about, we manage the top 10.

As a TPA, we take in about 25, currently in peak season, because our peak season is Memorial Day to Labor Day in our industry, we're taking roughly around 32,000-35,000 calls a day for various reasons. In most cases, it's because you have damage to your vehicle, and we're getting you set up with a scheduled appointment, a referral number, which starts in our CRM platform, which is Salesforce, to manage all the steps of the customer journey through, whether it be a human CSR or an AI agent CSR today. That's where our business model really kicks in to overdrive with leveraging the power of AI and some of the things that we've worked on over the past two+ years with Sierra. I know I said a mouthful there, so I'll pause.

Client 00:02:09

That's really helpful. I just want to make sure I understand this. The company is 13,000 employees across 900 physical locations. In terms of customer size, based on some of the clients you serve, what's the annual customer volume? Appreciate the annual call volume that you guys are seeing a day during peak season, but I'm trying to triangulate that to roughly how many consumers do you guys serve then, or corporate partners through your various entities.

Expert 00:02:38

2025, because we don't have 2026 data yet, but 2025, we served over eight million customers across our footprint. One thing I did leave out was we have 900+ stores, but we also have 7,000 mobile shops, which is a fancy way of saying one of our outfitted vans with all the equipment that a store would have, because a pretty big part of our business is coming to you, which is our value proposition, that separates us from our competition is you can come to us, but we can also come to your driveway or your place of work, with one of our 7,700, at last count, mobile vans out there across all 50 states.

Client 00:03:21

Got it. On the contact center side, roughly how many call center agents do you guys have in order to support your full operations?

Expert 00:03:29

We have 4,800 FTEs, and then we also have an additional 800 that are part-time or contingent.

Client 00:03:36

Got it. Are you staffing that 24/7 or just Monday through Friday business hours?

Expert 00:03:42

Monday through Friday, but we are taking into account, since we are national, the time zones. One of the things that I was going to also share, and this will give you a little bit more context around how we staff, is the pandemic changed all of us. It changed our business model going from a traditional contact center with five brick and mortar locations across our five sales regions. Roughly housing anywhere between 1,200-1,500 associates, to governors shutting all of those contact centers down, eventually us sending everyone home with a laptop and a headset, and we realized that it actually worked. There were **some growing pains**, obviously, especially if you had a newer CSR that needed someone there to assist, but we got good with digital technology and software like BlueJeans, being able to remote a job coach in to assist.

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We made the decision coming out of the pandemic in 2023 to sell all of our real estate. We now do not have any brick and mortar contact center locations. A little bit over two million sq. ft. we sold, and today **we have a 100% virtual contact center**. I share that because that is another thing that we had to think through was your question, which is, what are your hours? Our hours were easy to do business hours when we had a location on the West Coast. Now that CSR that lives in New York might be servicing a claim in SoCal. Our hours now are 7:00 A.M. to 7:00 P.M. to try and cover as much of all time zones as possible.

Client 00:05:23

Got it. In terms of use case for Sierra, could you just walk me through what that original use case was, when you decided to look at vendors in this space?

Expert 00:05:33

Absolutely. The use case was thinking of processes within our FNOL, or first notice of loss, intake process that were repetitive, that could free up our human CSRs to handle the bottleneck, which is still today, customer resolution escalations. When things do not go down, what we call the happy path, typically, what I see and observe is a human wants to talk to a human, even if it is just to vent. If we damaged your car, if the technician was rude, did not show up on time, all those things that we get customer complaints about, we have been able to shift a pretty significant size of our human CSRs to that team, which was understaffed when we were first looking at this initial use case.

To dive a little deeper into the first notice of loss process, it is you call one of our 1-800 numbers, or you go through one of our digital channels, and you let us know that **you have had damage to your vehicle**. Going back to us being a TPA, it may start with, let us just say you have Allstate. I don't know what your insurance carrier is, but let us just say you have Allstate. You reach out to Allstate through your Allstate app or State Farm app or whoever, and then you let them know that it is glass damage. They have a warm transfer over to a production environment, what we call insurance self-service site, that we manage on behalf of Allstate or State Farm or Liberty Mutual or GEICO or whoever. You think you are still in their environment, you are actually in ours.

You are inputting all of your information, or it is through authenticated paths, it's being pushed over. Things that you probably would never want to remember, your policy number, your VIN number of the vehicle that got damaged, all of that stuff, we get automatically through an API integration, and we then set you up based on your availability and what you want to do, an appointment.

The first use case was let us make sure that process works smooth in the voice channel and in the digital channel. If we don't have your information right, if we do not know that your deductible is $250 and then our screen is showing $500, **that causes friction**. If we don't have the right VIN of the vehicle that got damaged because maybe we don't have the most accurate information from your insurance carrier, **that causes friction**.

We wanted to solve for that first because it is very repetitive, as I mentioned early on. It is three questions that our CSRs ask or information you have to fill out, cause of loss, date of loss, and then an identifier, whether it could be your name, it could be your policy number, if you know it could be your address. That prompts a global search, and then we validate that you are you, and then you go to the next step. Early on in our AI journey with Sierra and with Agentforce, I may not have mentioned Agentforce in the screener, but we started our journey with Agentforce on the digital path because **they were the first-mover advantage in this space**.

Since we are an unlimited customer of Salesforce, we were provided the opportunity to pilot Agentforce almost two and a half years ago when they unveiled it at Dreamforce. We can dive deeper into that, but I am going to stick to Sierra for this example. Through the voice channel, which **Sierra is best in class** in, we basically said, Let us break up the customer journey into five pieces. First piece, get your information, validate you are you, kicks out to a human CSR for scheduling.

That was that first use case. Making sure that you are you, and then pulling those CSRs that are answering thousands of calls a day, basically sounding like a broken record, allowing for the API integration and the AI agent validating the API integration from that insurance carrier that the information is accurate. Do not pass go, then kick out for scheduling. There's a bunch more that has come since then, because we are very close to end-to-end. I wanted to just give you. This is what we wanted to solve for first.

There was definitely some metrics behind it. We were looking at things like average speed of answer, average handle time, cost per transaction, comparing the AI to a human CSR. What I will share is our board of directors and our CEO said, "Holy smokes, we didn't know it could be this good." We were fortunate in that not only were we working with a great partner in Sierra, another great partner in Salesforce, because Sierra had to integrate into CRM for **it to be successful, but also the fact that our first notice of loss intake process was pretty tight in terms of our APIs into our contracted clients**, because if we're getting the wrong information, then it's game over in the beginning. We were fortunate that use case was one off of flying colors.

It was a 90-day pilot that started in the Southwest region. Quickly, after about 45 days of that 90-day pilot, we started to share those KPIs, human versus AI agent, and we got the green light to go to all five regions just because of the ROI. A couple that I can give you as an example, average speed of answer. Most of our contracted customers have 20 seconds or better, meaning **you need to answer that phone within 20 seconds, or there could be a financial penalty per the terms of the contract. We were running in the pilot at about 18 seconds with human CSR, so pretty close to the danger level,** and we were running at under four seconds with our AI agents.

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Average cost per transaction, we typically look at a $7.50-$9 cost based on how many seconds that CSR is talking and trying to get that customer to verify all the information we need you to verify. We were at a less than $2 n the pilot for those transactions going through Sierra AI agents. The last one was handle time. How long are you talking? Right now, we're running around 850-900 seconds for human CSR. We're running around 250-300 seconds with the AI voice agent. That alone was enough to get us to step two pretty quickly.

Client 00:12:08

That makes sense. I didn't appreciate the speed of answer was baked into some of your corporate contracts, but makes sense if you're going to take it over as the TPA. The other question I had was. Appreciate the handle time reduction, did you guys reduce headcount of your live CSRs in this process and evolution of rolling out Sierra, given the efficiency gains, or are you just reallocating your existing CSRs to other types of cases?

Expert 00:12:35

I'd say, in the early phases, it was really around reallocation. We've got three different groups within our contact center that I lead. It's customer care, which I'd say, roughly, they were split up pretty evenly, so 33%, 33%, 33%, were handling a different function within what we do as a TPA. Customer care was the majority of those associates that were taking that first notice of loss intake information. We also have client care. Client care is the team that gets involved when things don't go right. **They're the ones getting yelled at and trying to resolve things** as quickly as possible. We have shop care. Shop care is managing the 7,000+ non-company-owned shops. With insurance, and you're probably well aware of this, you can't steer. Even as a TPA, we can't force you to use us.

You might have someone in mind that you've worked with for 10 years, and you want them to do the work. We manage it. We still handle the paper. We still ensure that that shop gets paid once the service is performed and completed. That team is working with what we call our affiliate network, which, as I mentioned, is 7,000 shops from local mom-and-pops to large multi-shop operations like say a Gerber or Caliber Collision that has a national footprint like ours. That team is managing those. Where the bottlenecks continue to be, even as we ramp up our AI penetration of AI agents in our workflow, is in those two teams. That's typically where the cycle time starts to add up.

In many cases, we also have SLAs with our clients around cycle time, and they benchmark us like they benchmark themselves, and most insurance carriers want to be 21 days or better. Basically, the time you reach out to them to the time you've been taken care of or they've issued a check for your loss. They usually are more stringent on us. We're typically in that 14-day range and trying to approve. Cycle time through the pilot with the AI agents was running around seven, under 10 days, typically seven to eight, versus the 17 to 18 that we saw on the human CSR side.

Biggest reason for that was being able to quickly pull information, quickly get appointments scheduled once we got to that next phase of the use case for the AI agents, which was appointment scheduling, because then we started to look at things like containment rate, bailouts, customer satisfaction of, and this is a question that happens in our NPS survey we send out, "Did you get the appointment that you were hoping for in a timely manner?"

We started to look at all those metrics as we moved down the line. To answer your question, it's really been about trying to fix the bottleneck, especially in a peak season that we're in today. Our peak season is Memorial Day to Labor Day, this is where we do about 60% of our revenue. That's what we've been monitoring at the start of May, and now we're right in the heat of it in July.

Client 00:15:48

Got it. In terms of the evaluation process itself, would love to understand just how you first heard about Sierra.

Expert 00:15:57

The irony is, and you may or may not know this, even though Agentforce is a great partner, Salesforce in general, like I said, we are spending low eight digits with Salesforce because we basically are a guinea pig anytime they bring something to us because they are so embedded in our tech stack. Agentforce's limitation is they do not have a voice AI agent. They only have a digital agent that can work within CRM and in their sales enablement platforms, code name Einstein Copilot. They did not invest in a voice agent because one of the phenomenons that we are seeing as a contact center organization is the shift to digital claims handling for a couple of reasons.

I think digital transformation happens to all of us. Even my mom can order stuff off of Amazon. That happened, then **you also have the internal cost pressures of a lot of our clients**, especially insurance carriers, that know that it costs less to file a claim digitally than it does to call one of our CSRs or one of their CSRs. In many cases, we kick out from a human CSR back to the insurance carrier's contact center. Now you are paying twice the amount you probably should be paying if the information is easily, readily available through the digital channel and AI agents are helping guide and navigate that person or customer through the process flow of the site.

A couple of things that we looked at were really around who had a platform versus who was a function, when we started to look at the evaluation process, then basically go through interviews, demos, and then the pilot actually happened that I mentioned earlier. It was a

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pretty extensive process. It was a lot of research on our end because AI, two and a half years ago, we did not know which way was up or which way was down. We have gotten a lot further now that we have got several deployments within our workflow, but we are still learning.

We also hired two third-party consultants that have helped guide us through this journey. Accenture and Berkeley are both helping us through this process. They've learned, because our business is nuanced. As a TPA, you are the customer of a customer's customer versus direct to consumer or direct to B2B. Hopefully that helps answer your question a little bit.

Client 00:18:23

That is helpful. Who else did you compare Sierra against in your evaluation process?

Expert 00:18:29

We had a pretty broad evaluation process, if you will. We looked at head-to-head competitors of Sierra. The closest one to Sierra to me, coming out of that evaluation, was Decagon. Very similar in their setup, even similar in how they charge performance-based versus usage-based. Decagon was probably the closest, but Fin was another one. We looked at Zendesk, we looked at 6sense, and then we also looked at a couple of platform providers, because we knew that if we were to pick someone like Sierra, which we did, we also needed to have best-in-class platform for contact center provider that had an integration and an AI layer themselves.

We actually did another RFP where we switched from our 10-plus-year provider, Avaya, to Genesys because of Genesys' ability to easily integrate a Sierra or a Decagon or an Intercom on top of their platform to have that un-native, if you will, AI agent working in that platform to help route IVRs seamlessly. Last but not least, we then put another RFP out for CRM platform providers. Salesforce beat out Oracle, Microsoft, Zoho, and a couple of others because of their ability to integrate seamlessly into Sierra. One of the interesting things about Sierra is Bret, who is the CEO of Sierra and founder of Sierra, he was brought in by Salesforce.

Going back to what I told you around they do not have a solution for voice, and I do not think they are ever going to try and go down that path of a solution for voice, simply because if I go back to 2020, that is probably a safe timeframe. Six years ago, 75% of all claims that came to us came by the phone. Going back to the digital transformation comment, we now are getting 60% of all claims coming to us through one of our dot com sites or our mobile app. It is flipped, and we have clients pushing for that cost containment and claim paneling to get to 90% digital at some point.

There are some really aggressive digital-first insurance carriers and managed fleets out there that are already over 70%, 75% digital, and we do not see **that slowing** down. I think the game that is being played right now is who is going to be best in class in both. Sierra is already, I would say Decagon, based on my recollection of the evaluation, was a 1B as it pertained to our evaluation and our scorecards. If they continue to focus on being best in class in voice, they are going to get left behind because they might only have 10% of the pie here in the next three to five years.

Client 00:21:18

Yes. I just want to make sure I heard you right. You said roughly six years ago, 70% of all your claims came in via phone call versus now 60% of all your claims come in from a digital site or property of yours?

Expert 00:21:34

Correct. It is flipped, and a lot of it has been driven by the customer. You might know this, and hopefully you have not had to file a claim in recent history. If you have, it is hard to get a hold of anyone at the insurance carrier, and that is done by design. You go on the website, there are no numbers. They have taken 1-800 numbers down. They are trying to drive you to go to libertymutual.com and file a claim or use the mobile app. A lot of that is being driven by the insurance carrier, and we are just facilitating that through our digital capabilities, creating white-labeled sites, as we call them, where we manage the glass repair environment. Once you let us know that the only thing damaged on your vehicle was glass, you come straight to us.

If **it's glass with additional damage**, the insurance carrier has to then get the adjuster involved and come out, take pictures. Let's say **you ran into your garage and your bumper's messed** up as well as your windshield is cracked. That doesn't go to us initially, but it may come to us later after you've gotten the body work fixed. **I would say that best in class for us** right now in the digital channel is 75%. That same carrier that was 75% four years ago was 45% digital. That's how fast it's accelerating today.

Client 00:23:03

Got it. In terms of the decision, once you guys made the decision to go with Sierra, can you maybe just walk me through how easy or difficult the implementation process was?

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Expert 00:23:15

Yes. I want to start with why we went with them as well, and that this is what made the process easier. Let me try and close the circle pretty quickly for you. When we brought everyone back in to present their proposal to us on what they thought we needed in the pilot and what products or usage level we were going to be using, and how that would scale up over time based on the steps and the use cases we adopted and when, Sierra was the only one that came in and didn't present anything, and that's what stood out to me. Decagon came in and presented their best AI agents and gave us really cool videos of what it could do and issue resolution internally, customer interaction, and taking action externally.

Sierra came in and said, "Hey, you probably were expecting to see a presentation. We don't have one. What we want to do is sit down with you and understand all of the exceptions in your intake process." Why does it kick out to a human when you're going through your current self-service model, which is basically a dumb chatbot that can help you, but typically it's a frequently asked question list that is pretty generic, and most of the time it doesn't solve your issue, then **you get frustrated,** and you either call us or you go to a competitor down the street. They wanted to understand the exceptions that would make something not go through our flow.

They also wanted to understand our flow in general. They said, "Can we schedule some time two weeks from now to come back in?" They came back in. They said, "This is what we are going to do. This is the project roadmap. This is how fast we are going to implement it. This is the integration steps needed. These are the resources that we will provide, and these are the resources we need from you."

With the relationship with Salesforce, they collaborated. They looked at the first place we need to integrate AI agents is not in the contact center, which we thought were. We thought that it was really an overlay of the Genesys platform, like I mentioned earlier. They said, "No. If the customer journey and the referral number for that customer lives in CRM, then we need to start with the integration between Salesforce CRM and us."

We were pleasantly surprised that their integration into Salesforce CRM is pretty much native. It is about as easy as them being a Salesforce product. If an IT leader was on this call with me, they would not use the word easy, but relatively speaking. Within two weeks, we were able to start to do some dev environment testing to see if everything was working the way it was supposed to work. Within less than three and a half weeks to a month, we had our first pilot up and running in the CRM system, that AI agent taking that referral number, aligning it with what the API was given during that FNOL call.

It went from dev environment to live environment within a month. As we have started to get into more complex cycles of the process, going back to the appointment scheduling, where multiple APIs have to occur. To give you an example of that, the only API needed for that first notice of loss is into our CRM system, because that is where the information is being pushed by the insurance carrier, as an example, into our system. All of your information, name, address, VIN number, all of that sitting in CRM, during that initial intake.

Whereas when you start to get to appointment scheduling, that AI agent not only has to go back to CRM, because now you have said, "I want to use your company," then that is a whole different decision tree than saying, "I will call back," or, "I do not want to use you. I want to use Bob's Auto Glass down the street." It also has to go into our Oracle Fusion and look at the part availability of the part that matches your car. It also has to go into CCC, which is our vehicle database, to make sure that the part that we selected is the right part for your car.

We can go down that path in a minute, but that is a big use case in our industry because of the complexity of vehicles, ADAS. Your car is probably a rolling computer if you are driving a newer one. All of those things have to happen simultaneously, then also read the right script, because every carrier has different scripting, and every carrier has different scripting depending on what state they are in. Making sure that you are reading the right information for a deductible state versus zero deductible state.

All of this is happening at the same time, once you declare that you want to move forward with getting work done. I just wanted to give you that real-life example, because it goes from fairly simple to then, as we moved into the next phase of the customer journey with AI agents from Sierra, **it then got a lot more complicated** quickly.

Client 00:28:16

Got it. That makes sense as you went through more complex workflows. In terms of feature set, what would you describe are the best features of Sierra?

Expert 00:28:27

I would say that the best feature sets are their latency. I would say their voice augmentation and realistic tone, because I am reading these NPS feedback from our promoter surveys, passive survey responses, and detractor survey responses. One of the things that is coming up, especially in the promoters, is they do not know that they were talking to AI, **which is pleasantly** surprising and a good thing. I am wondering if one of the things **that is probably keeping them at best of their class** is they continue to put a lot of money into making it real, and making it as realistic as possible versus long pauses.

Also, an example I will give you, because we just started this pilot on the West Coast, we have several AI agents that can speak up to seven languages. We are starting another pilot, like I said, on the West Coast, where it is speaking Spanish, it is speaking different dialects of Spanish, so Dominican versus Mexican versus Castilian. They now have different dialects within languages, in addition to the fact that they

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can speak multiple languages. One of the cool things, I was listening to an audio recording, just over about two months ago now, where the AI agent answered in English and the policyholder, or customer, I should say, was calling in and started speaking in Italian.

The AI agent switched immediately. In the very next response, the AI agent was speaking in Italian. Those are the nuances that I think continue to set them apart, is it is smart enough to recognize, oh, I started English and I should not have, but immediately flipping through to the right language. The other thing that in terms of feedback loop and them being nimble, because I think this is another reason why Sierra stands out, is **they are very nimble**. They take feedback and they do something with it versus, "Thank you, and we are going to continue down our project roadmap."

Some of the feedback we got from the NPS detractors and passives was, "I got my claim resolved, but it was awkwardly silent or did not feel empathetic." Now, those agents are basically patting you on your back, because when you call us, you do not want to talk to us anyway. **You are having a bad day** coming into the situation, but also adding things like typing noise, background noise, ceiling fans in the background, and they did that within a timeframe of less than 30 days of adding those additives from our NPS detractor surveys that we were feeding them through our weekly touch bases.

That was another thing that stood out, is they are nimble enough, at least today, as a company **that is growing** astronomically, but small enough to say, "We are going to put a dedicated resource on this, and we are going to fix the issue that you are getting consistent feedback on." They have done that about 2X or 3X throughout the pilot and now in full deployment as well.

Client 00:31:37

Got it. On the voice quality and realism, do you know if they are using a partner to produce the voices in the agent, like an ElevenLabs, or are they building the voice model themselves in-house?

Expert 00:31:50

Today, they are building the voice model in-house. It's a great question, because a lot of their executives came from either OpenAI, Anthropic, or ElevenLabs. They've got probably one of the most talented teams that no one knows about. They're doing, I'd say, probably 95% of it in-house. They just came out with the new Ghostwriter technology, and that was done by them, which the Ghostwriter technology is something that we're looking to quickly implement in some of the predictive modeling and forecasting of our finance team when they're ready to test it, because the Ghostwriter will just learn from past events and predict future outcomes, and that's something that we've been missing as a team.

We budget in our space based on weather, and that's probably not the best indicator, but it's been directionally right for 30 years, and we're trying to get to a better way of managing forecast, managing peak, managing demand spikes, and then going back to the fact that **parts proliferation is a big challenge in our industry**, knowing where we should have more Ford F-150 windshields versus Tesla windshields. We have an idea, Texas versus California, but that's still not good enough for where we want to go.

I would say right now, while they're still nimble, they're trying to build it all in-house. I also wouldn't be shocked if they're doing it in-house for a reason. To me, that reason would be being bought by a Salesforce or a Microsoft or one of these larger enterprise organizations that is getting left behind in certain aspects of AI, but still really good in other aspects with their Copilot products.

Client 00:33:29

Got it. In terms of a feature wish list or something that you think the product is missing or needs to be improved, where would you point to areas that they should focus on making better or add to it?

Expert 00:33:41

I would say digital. As we've talked about a little bit, the digital channels are the way of the future. There's no way around it. Just about everyone has a smartphone, unless you're just purposely trying to avoid the technology at this point, and so a lot of things are being driven by digital. When I think about our future outlook, because you asked the question, are we shifting resources or are we reducing? There's going to come to a rubber meets the road moment where we're going to reduce resources because it's not going to make any sense to have thousands of CSRs when we have our AI agents handling over 60%-70% of the intake volume.

Today, **we're around 35%-40%, scaling** up gradually as we continue to identify areas of improvement, and then also the fact that working with insurance carriers is a very highly regulated industry, but they're starting to get comfortable with AI. Once the GEICOs and the State Farm and the Liberty Mutual say, "You know what? It's game on. We feel comfortable from a cybersecurity perspective, a firewall, confidential information, hallucination," all the things that **they're worried about today**, then I think you're going to start to see a lot more than what you see today. You're probably reading the articles.

We're seeing companies that might lay off 350-500 employees because of AI, and then we're also seeing companies backtrack and rehire more tenured employees, especially in the automotive industry, because AI didn't solve the problems that they thought they were going to

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solve immediately. I think that we're still in the early stages of it, but I think that once everyone's comfortable with AI, when companies like Sierra are omni-channel, because I think that's where they're trying to get.

Everyone talks about having an omni-channel contact center, and many of the platforms that we've talked about, like Avaya, like Genesys, like NICE, they do a really good job of having an omni-channel option. The AI agents, it seems like, have either taken a direction to go digital only or voice only. Sierra went voice only. Now they're in chat, which they're really good in chat, but their blind spot is still pure digital. You go to one of our dot-com sites, that Sierra agent is just as good working in a native CRM or a Snowflake environment as an Agentforce digital-focused agent or a Talkdesk or a ServiceNow. **Those AI agents are very good in the digital channels**, whereas I think Sierra was thinking more of the traditional telecom when they came onto the scene.

Client 00:36:24

That makes sense. From a pricing perspective, do you find Sierra to be cheap or expensive, and why?

Expert 00:36:33

I would say that they're cheap because they're outcome-based. Here's why. They align with you on what the outcome is. Most companies will say the outcome-based pricing model is did the agent get from point A to point B, then they give you a tiered structure based on volume commitment. That's pretty much how it's set up today. Sierra will sit down with you and say, "What are you trying to get out of this?" Like, we talked about that first notice of loss, that first step. We were just trying to get out of it a 98% or better verification of the customer calling in. If there's no outlier, like **we're getting bad information from the insurance carrier** or they're renting a car and they don't know who the rental company is.

If that's the case, 98% or better, we pay you. I think the cool thing with Sierra, going back to them being small enough and nimble enough, is that we've gone down this path of it's getting more and more complex because of more workflows being interjected into the process. We're then negotiating the price. An example I will give is going back to that less than $2 example of that verification and that transaction process of the first notice of loss. It's between $4-5 when you start talking about scheduling, part sourcing, reaching out to the store to make sure that that schedule is in place, making sure that that part matches the VIN through CCC. They're happy to negotiate with us, but we're also going to look at our ROI and be fair.

Whereas a lot of the other partners, I wouldn't call them not being fair, but they're just basically saying it's black and white. We're going to charge X amount for this, even if they don't really understand complexity in the process. We might be unique as a TPA, but we have really liked how we've started to outline the pricing, and that's been outlined. Currently, we've got a four-year contract that expires at the end of 2028 with Sierra. It's really about, we've come back and done two amendments to the contract so far because we continue to build out what the process and what the involvement of the AI agent looks like.

As we start to look at other avenues, some of the future roadmap considerations are diving a little deeper into not only the supply chain piece of getting the right part at the right time before the appointment happens, but also drilling down to the store level, going back to those 900 individual store locations and making sure that the store has all the information that they need. Special considerations, that this person is coming in an hour early now, they called back into the contact center, because, right now, we have a centralized IVR at the contact center. You cannot call one of our stores. We know that **that is a friction point for customers**, but it is done for a reason.

The challenge with that is if the human that took the initial call is not working and no one has picked up that update to that referral or job, then the store may not have gotten notification that now this customer is coming in an hour earlier than what their appointment was because they have got to get to work or whatever the situation is. We are now looking at a pilot, the AI agents being able to push down information, multiple ways of communication, email, phone call, memo, in the diary notes of Salesforce so that there is no way, unless that store is just not opening their computer that day, that they miss that that customer is coming in early.

I just share that because it is a revolving door, and it is a kind of an ebb and flow situation around pricing, then **I would imagine at some point, the challenge** right now is we are still in the early stages, even though more and more people are getting comfortable with AI, more and more companies are starting to implement it. I would say 80% of customers out there, of partners like Sierra or Decagon or any of the others, are probably using them internally for **processes improvement** internally.

Where we, being a TPA, we knew that our internal processes were really well because we have been in the TPA business for over 25 years. Externally, **we are getting a lot of pressure from our customers** to be better, and make less mistakes, improve the policyholder experience, improve their likelihood to renew scores. All the things that they push us to do on their behalf, we have identified in many ways that AI can help us get there.

Client 00:41:15

That makes sense. In the amendments that you made to the contract, I would imagine that was priced and revised up, or you guys were expanding the contract as you found more use cases?

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Expert 00:41:26

In some cases, **it was a price down** because we were giving them a higher volume commitment. There were times where if the process got more complex, we might say, the cost per transaction shouldn't be $2.20. We're now asking this AI agent to, in any of the examples I've given, contact a store now where they didn't have to. We're looking at what does that cost for the human to do it? Trying to aggregate that out, also piloting it to see if it works, first of all, before we agree to any price. Come back to say, **we have a 35%-40% cost reduction by letting AI** do it. Let's be good partners and give Sierra 10% of that, or whatever that number is.

That's how we've been doing it so far. The hopes are, we're the pioneer and exclusive in our industry with Sierra. They can't work with anyone in our industry until our contract's up, and they might have some ability to negotiate that when we get closer to renewal to continue that exclusivity. If it doesn't happen and they say, we love working with you, but we still need to grow our share of customers as well, hopefully by then, we've established a pretty good baseline, so the pricing doesn't continue to be fluid. Right now it's fluid, but I think it's because there aren't a lot of people that are doing it the way we're doing it.

Even in traditional telecom companies like an AT&T or a Verizon, for example, that's doing a lot of piloting as well, this is still, for lack of a better term, the. because volume is volume, but there's always an exception that no one has ever seen, the agent's never seen. The speed of getting these AI agents up to speed and training is accelerating. What does that do to cost? If it took me six months to get our first AI agent with Sierra up to speed to where we felt like it could handle over 95% of all scenarios, then we train another one, because what we've done, and I would believe other companies have done this as well, is our AI is training our AI. Our first rendition with Sierra, her name was Scarlett.

I affectionately call her, because she has a female avatar. Scarlett taught Gray, who was our second iteration. What it took Scarlett six months to learn from all of the roadblocks, blind spots, customer questions, regulations, it took Gray one month. The next AI agent, our first Spanish-speaking AI agent, it took maybe 30 days, or maybe 15 days. When I say that, less IT resources needed from our side, less IT resources needed from Sierra's side, faster deployment time, lower cost, potentially keeping that cost per interaction around the same if the level of complexity is the same.

When we think of any of these AI agents or any deployment of something new in your tech stack, you are talking, I would say the upfront setup cost is probably at least 35%-40% of your first year spend of that product or service. We have seen that decline. It is going down in that case, but as we adopt more use cases, we are spending more per transaction, if that makes sense?

Client 00:44:47

That makes sense. It sounds like your intent at the end of the four-year contract is to likely renew with Sierra? Is that like the current thinking?

Expert 00:44:57

Yeah. **The cost of switching is pretty high** when you have got someone that is this embedded in your process now. If **we would have stayed in the first notice of loss intake** only and never decided to move into store scheduling or supply chain or even marketing. A big part of what Sierra does pre, prior, and post-appointment is reach out to you. Whether it is a phone call, whether it is an offer and acceptance email, for reminders, and then auto-generated NPS surveys, Sierra is now taking on a lot of that customer outreach that we were paying another enablement company to do. **We have been able to reduce our vendor base with the functionality** that Sierra continues to expand into.

Now they are starting to look into sales enablement and customer outreach. As they grow, we are able to save money by reducing partners that only focus or specialize into that in the beginning. If they keep doing that, I think that just increases and makes **the story more sticky** for us to stick with them. Just going back to best in class, but also being nimble as our customers change their expectations of us and what we should do as a TPA as we move more into this digital-first world, they are moving with us.

Now, if someone comes out of nowhere, just like Sierra came out of nowhere, then there is always that opportunity to put things back out to bid, go through another formal evaluation and another pilot. All of those things are highly possible because we do want to make sure that we are being market competitive and not letting innovation run by us because we are loyal to our partners. We do not want to be loyal to a fault, but we want to be loyal enough.

If you were to ask me a percentage, we are probably 80% likely to renew our contract unless something like I just mentioned happens or some significant challenge with their balance sheet, because we have non-obsolescence clauses in all of our contracts, so we definitely would monitor that, or if there is some type of a data breach or security breach that they cannot recover from. There is always these outliers or things that are uncontrollable, but if they are to continue to perform the way they have been performing, I would imagine they are going to be in our tech stack for a long time.

Client 00:47:19

That makes sense. On a scale of 0-10, how likely would you be to recommend Sierra to someone else?

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Expert 00:47:27

I would say a 10.5, and here's why. We just had our customer experience conference in Orlando last November, and we do that every other year, so this was the year to do it. At that customer experience conference, many of our top clients, so the GEICOs, you name it, they're there. They're seeing innovations in how we handle their policyholders from a service delivery perspective. They're also wanting to know what our future roadmap looks like as it pertains to digital first. Bret came and sat on the panel, and so we exposed him to 70 insurance carriers and probably multiple other Tier one partners like Bosch. It was amazing to see how many people pulled out their smartphones as he was talking, giving his bio.

You may or may not know his bio, but he came out the gate hot and said, when I was working, a spare project of mine, **I ended up creating Google Maps by accident**. Everyone looked up and said, wait a minute, that's the guy that created Google Maps? He did it as a hobby. Everyone knew right off the gate that this guy has a lot of smarts. Everyone had their phone up. It looked like a concert. They were googling Sierra. We got so many questions after that around, can you connect us with Sierra?

We're working currently with MIT or Stanford d.school around how we can incorporate AI into our workflow processes as an insurance carrier. We want to get their feedback and potentially partner with them. That's why I say 10.5, because we already recommended him to 70 of our most valued insurance carriers last November. He's been in meetings, flying across the country, meeting with some of the biggest carriers that you can name.

Client 00:49:20

Got it. Just out of curiosity, would love to just get your perspective on the full duplex speech-to-speech models that OpenAI released earlier this week with their GPT Live launch.

Expert 00:49:32

It is exciting. When I think of people that have brand recognition, OpenAI, obviously with ChatGPT, no matter which large language model you use now, whether it is Copilot or Gemini or Claude, ChatGPT is basically the Uber to the Lyft in my mind because of them being first. Now they are taking it to the next level with the voice. I have also heard rumblings that they are working on their digital twin, and there is a couple of companies that are pushing for the next level of AI agent as well, will be someone that looks like you or me, that talks just like you or me based on how we train.

I can see that in the contact center environment as well. We actually are reaching out to OpenAI, because like I said, we started our journey with OpenAI when we tried to do it in-house. It was cost prohibitive. We do have a pretty good relationship with them, then everyone at Sierra basically came from either OpenAI or ElevenLabs or potentially another company. They are all in the space. He is chairman of the board of OpenAI, so he is going to help us foster that communication.

The cool thing is Sierra does not even see it as a threat. They see it as another door that maybe OpenAI can open first, and then they can try and perfect it in their own way. It is pretty exciting what they are doing with that because text-to-speech in the way of that path, but they are taking it to the next level, so it is pretty cool.

Client 00:51:08

It sounds like for you guys, it does not really change your approach or path with Sierra. You are going to stay the course with them in customer service and customer workflows, even if they are using a different model architecture, but the voice quality is still there.

Expert 00:51:23

Correct. I think where OpenAI solutions might be viable, I think about our mobile techs. If they are struggling with getting a car fixed, they are usually calling a help desk. They might be watching a video on YouTube, and I think if AI can work through that way of, "On the job, I need help. Can you tell me how to replace this windshield on this Cybertruck because I have never done one before. "

Them looking at a person basically walking them through that is digital based on that voice to the video, I think that might be a use case for us. I think in the contact center, it is going to stay primarily the same because we do not get a lot of that intake. We are still getting the intake traditionally, but then we are pushing it out through AI agents in a newer, more creative way.

Client 00:52:13

Got it. That's super helpful. This has been really insightful.

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